CHAPTER FOURTEEN

TATA MOTORS

A Passion for Cars

Ratan has an enduring and obsessive passion for cars. As *The Economist* commented, 'Ratan Tata may be the patriarch of Indian business and head of the sprawling conglomerate that bears his name, but few doubt that his first love is Tata Motors.' His knowledge about automobiles is incredible, says Raman Dhawan, former MD of Tata Africa Holdings who was deputed in the late 1970s to explore the markets for Tata Motors in the continent. He adds that Ratan can astonish car geeks with his in-depth knowledge of vehicles. He narrates an exchange between Ratan and the driver of a vintage Mercedes car assigned by the South African government for his use. The chauffeur had hung his cap on the dashboard to hide the empty space left by a radio that had been removed for repair. Ratan surprised him by telling him the details of the radio that was supposed to be in that slot.

Ratan wears his love for cars on his sleeve. In 2015, in his address at the Automotive Hall of Fame, Michigan, he said: 'Let me just say that on all the years in the varying capacities that I've tried to work in India, the most fascinating period of time that I've had is in the automotive area.'

He is so enthralled by cars that during long board meetings, he would be found doodling car designs, recalls Percy Siganporia, MD of Tata Consumer Products from 2004 to 2012. Coincidentally, one of Ratan's first chairmanships of a Tata company was of TELCO in 1988.

Established in September 1945, the story of TELCO began when Tata Sons acquired the East Indian Railways' run-down Tatanagar workshops in Jamshedpur for Rs 25 lakh, with the objective of manufacturing steam locomotives and boilers for the Indian Railways. From this humble beginning, the company, which was renamed Tata Motors in 2003, has